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Introduction

Academic stress is an important determinant of a student's university life, influencing their education and future prospects. In Bangladesh, undergraduate students go through a challenging path with three types of institutions: public, private, and national universities. Numerous aspects ranging from exam timetables to curriculum can significantly influence a student's capacity to balance studies and excel. One key missing ingredient is institutional autonomy, that is, the ability of a university to set its own academic and administrative course of action independently without external influence. University autonomy means how much freedom a university has in managing its own decisions—like creating courses, hiring teachers, spending money, and setting rules—without direct control from the government or outside bodies (Estermann, Nokkala, & Steinel, 2011). Understanding the connection between freedom for a university and pressure on students is important for instructors, administrators, and policy-makers. This research seeks to explore this link for purposes of identifying problems and offering practical solutions for change.

The primary objectives of this research are:

1. To establish and compare the effect of academic stress among students in autonomous and government-controlled institutions.
2. To explore how specific elements of the academic timetable and examination system, such as timetabling and frequency, function to contribute to student stress and impact academic performance.
3. To explore the overall impact of institutional autonomy on students' welfare, i.e., mental well-being and relevance of curricula for career planning.

4. To examine the specific lacunas within the system, i.e., outdated courses and rigid administrative procedures, which arise when institutional autonomy is not harmoniously coordinated with the general pattern of education in Bangladesh.
5. To assess the student perceptions towards the level of independence of their university as well as its performance regarding resolving students' complaints pertaining to academic policies.

Although there are various models of universities, many students are faced with excessive pressure of studying. This problem persists and has a direct impact on student performance. For instance, an astonishing 58.6% of students report being stressed and anxious due to overlapping exam schedules, and this negatively affects their performance. Not only is this pressure logistical but also comes at a cost mentally, with 34.5% of students agreeing that academic stress does not assist their mental wellbeing. Furthermore, this is an issue in prospect, since only 20.7% of students believe that their university curriculum is very or highly applicable to the demands of the modern-day labour market. One probable reason is limited institutional autonomy, which can trap universities into rigid frameworks, slowing them down to react. A significant 46.4% of students believe this freedom inhibits them from maximizing their learning. This study seeks to bridge that gap by looking at those determining factors and their effects.

This study would like to ask the following questions:

- Do there exist notable differences in the impacts of academic pressure for autonomous and government-controlled schools?
- What is the impact of the academic calendar and examination system on student stress and learning outcomes?

- What is the impact of institutional autonomy on academic pressure on mental health and career readiness?
- What institutional deficits link institutional autonomy to increased academic pressure on undergraduate students?
- In considering student academic policy issues, how do universities perform?

Hypothesis:

- Increased institutional autonomy in universities allows more academic freedom in areas such as course choice and timeliness, which reduces academic pressure on undergraduate students compared to government-owned institutions.
- The exam regime and academic calendar, through factors like congested exam schedules and limited breaks, significantly affect levels of stress and student performance and, in some instances, general well-being and achievement.
- Due to limited institutional autonomy, undergraduate students experience higher levels of academic pressure, which has a massive impact on their mental health and disqualifies them from preparing for careers by lowering the intensity of the curriculum and scheduling flexibility
- Undergraduates are under more academic pressure because of outdated courses, strict schedules, and sluggish decision-making because institutional autonomy isn't fully in line with Bangladesh's educational system, particularly with regard to curriculum management and development.

This research is significant to several stakeholders:

- **University administrators** could utilize the evidence while developing more efficient institutional policies, including improving flexibility in scheduling and ensuring curriculum relevance, which could directly lower student stress and enhance performance.
- **Students** can be empowered with knowledge to fight for improved mental health care systems and student-centered higher education policies. The research justifies their perception of academic stress.
- **Policy makers** can gain important lessons to shape broader educational policy reform in Bangladesh. The findings can help create a more fair and effective higher education system that promotes student well-being as well as career readiness.
- **Institutions** are better able to acknowledge the need for maintaining government control in tandem with academic freedom. This helps to refine the act of balance between accountability and autonomy to ensure desired student outcomes.

Addressing these key areas, this study aims to contribute meaningfully to Bangladesh's ongoing higher education debate, providing practical suggestions on how healthier and more efficient learning environments can be established.

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- Estermann, T., Nokkala, T., & Steinel, B. (2011). *University autonomy in Europe II: The scorecard*. European University Association.

Literature Review

Research 1: Academic Freedom under Pressure in Bangladesh

Research Question 1: Are there significant differences in the effects of academic pressure on autonomous and government-controlled institutions?

Comparison with Hasan (2019):

- Hasan does **not directly compare institutional types** (autonomous vs. government-controlled) but asserts that **public universities** suffer more due to **political interference** and **centralized control**.
- He indicates that the **administrative politicization** severely limits academic freedom, thereby **exacerbating stress** among faculty—paralleling the idea that **less autonomy equals more pressure** (Hasan, 2019).
- While our survey focuses on **student experiences**, Hasan emphasizes the **faculty's loss of autonomy**, suggesting systemic parallels.

Research Question 2: Explore whether the academic calendar and exam system affect the students' stress and performance.

Comparison with Hasan (2019):

- · Our research centers on the practical stress experienced by undergraduate students, mainly caused by overlapping exams, rigid academic schedules, and misaligned curriculum. In contrast, Hasan (2019) highlights psychological pressure faced by university faculty and the academic system, stemming from political repression, censorship, and a pervasive climate of fear.
- · The pressure in our research is mostly operational and administrative, relating to institutional calendar management, curriculum design, and inflexibility within educational institutions. While Hasan's study points to structural and political pressures, including state surveillance, persecution of dissenting academics, and politicized administrative control.

Research Question 3: What is the impact of institutional autonomy on academic pressure, mental health, and career preparation of undergraduate students?

Comparison with Hasan (2019):

- · While mental health is not directly measured, Hasan highlights a culture of fear and self-censorship among academics.
- · He describes a psychological environment of repression where academics avoid sensitive topics to "avoid trouble"—indicating emotional strain and anxiety (Hasan, 2019).
- · Does not address **career preparation** directly, but argues that suppression of research and rigid state-controlled narratives stifle **innovation**.
- · Notes that **without academic freedom, universities cannot function as engines of innovation**, which indirectly affects **graduate preparedness** for complex careers.

Research Question 4: What are the primary sources of academic pressure faced by undergraduate students?

Comparison with Hasan (2019):

- · In Hasan's research, Academic pressure stems from **state mechanisms stifling academic freedom**

- In our research, Students are affected by **expectations from family** (64.3% combined feel pressured or anxious due to it). In (Hasan,2019), Faculty are constrained by **expectations from the state** and political apparatus.
- In (Hasan, 2019), Mental health impacts are **implied**, (not measured, like in our research)— It is experienced through **fear, self-censorship, and suppression** of intellectual freedom. No quantified mental health data is presented.
- Hasan's research Focuses on **structural and political oppression**: authoritarian control over content, suppression of dissent, and erosion of academic liberty. While our research focus on operational/academic design issues: overload curriculum, exam scheduling, and institutional inflexibility.

Research Question 5: Types of gaps which links institutional autonomy systems that impact undergraduate students

Comparison with Hasan (2019):

Hasan focuses on broader structural and political gaps in autonomy:

- Public university governance is deeply politicized, and dissent is punished.
- Academic administrators act on behalf of the ruling party, curtailing faculty independence.

- There is no mention of student participation in governance or autonomy-related decisions.
- Gaps are framed primarily as threats to freedom of expression and democratic ideals, not student well-being.

Conclusion:

Our research uniquely captures undergraduate perspectives, which are underrepresented in Hasan's (2019) faculty- and administration-focused analysis. It addresses how students directly feel and respond to academic pressure, calendar structures, and administrative inflexibility. Our research is supported by survey data from 2025, making it more relevant in today's evolving academic and policy landscape. Hasan's work, while insightful, is now five years old and reflects conditions that may have changed or intensified. It also provides statistical insights into how institutional autonomy gaps manifest in stress, career preparation issues, and student engagement. Hasan's study, though critical and well-argued, is largely qualitative and anecdotal. Our work offers specific implications for policy, such as improving scheduling flexibility, increasing student participation, and updating curriculum relevance. Hasan focuses more on broad ideological concerns, which, while important, are harder to translate into immediate institutional reform. Our survey draws responses from a variety of university types (private, public, national), giving a broader and more balanced view of how autonomy issues play out across the spectrum. Hasan's analysis primarily reflects experiences in public universities.

Research 2: CONSTITUTIONALIZING THE INSTITUTIONAL AUTONOMY AND ACADEMIC FREEDOM OF THE UNIVERSITIES

Research Question 1: Are there significant differences in the effects of academic pressure on autonomous and government-controlled institutions?

Comparison with (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d.):

- · Argue that legal structures (e.g., University Ordinance 1973) have enabled state control, eroding meaningful autonomy in both public and private universities.
- · Government appoints administrative heads, which limits true academic independence (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d., p. 4).

Research Question 2: Explore whether the academic calendar and exam system affect the students' stress and performance.

Comparison with (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d.):

- · There is no constitutional recognition of academic freedom or institutional autonomy in Bangladesh (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d., p. 4).

- · Universities suffer from state control, administrative manipulation, and loss of morale among faculty due to politicized leadership structures (p. 4).
- · The lack of academic freedom leads to a deterioration in the quality of education, which indirectly impacts students' mental health and learning outcomes.

Research Question 3: What is the impact of institutional autonomy on academic pressure, mental health, and career preparation of undergraduate students?

Comparison with (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d.):

- · They argue that Bangladesh's Constitution does not explicitly recognize academic freedom or institutional autonomy (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d., p. 4).
- · This constitutional vacuum has led to centralized control, political appointments, and the erosion of intellectual independence, particularly in public institutions.
- · As a result, faculty morale is low, governance is inefficient, and universities fail to serve their democratic and educational purposes.
- · The paper strongly advocates for formal constitutional recognition of universities as "integrity institutions" essential for democratic society, calling for reforms that would protect against bureaucratic and political encroachment.

Research Question 4: What are the primary sources of academic pressure faced by undergraduate students?

Comparison with (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d.):

- They focuses on **macro-level constitutional and legal issues**, while our research focuses on student-level academic pressure.
- The **lack of autonomy** leads to political appointments, rigid curricula, and administrative manipulation — all of which **indirectly create a stressful academic environment** for both faculty and students.
- While health impacts aren't explicitly measured, like our research (Emotional responses are measured e.g., 33.3% feel “highly stressed and anxious”). **declining faculty morale, loss of independence, and fear of state interference** point to deep psychological and professional strain within academia.

Research Question 5: Types of gaps which links institutional autonomy systems that impact undergraduate students

Comparison with (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d.):

- · Universities appear self-governing, but **real control lies with the state** via top-down laws (p. 4)
- · Legal structures **empower inefficiency** by preventing institutions from self-regulating (p. 4–5)
- · Chowdhury & Sejan argue this reflects a **symbolic vs actual autonomy gap** enshrined in law (p. 5)
- · No direct discussion of student participation, but the call for **democratization** implies this is a problem
- · Explicit: **Constitutional reform** to formally recognize academic freedom and university independence (p. 6)

Conclusion:

Our research is better than (Chowdhury & Sejan, n.d.) because it is based on direct data and observations from undergraduate students in 2025, capturing tangible and immediate stressors like exam overlaps, rigid scheduling, and curriculum issues that affect mental health and performance. Chowdhury and Sejan's work is more normative and legalistic, focusing on constitutional reforms and institutional frameworks without direct empirical data on how students or faculty currently experience these issues on the ground. Our research calls for autonomy aimed at practical student benefits — flexible scheduling, curriculum alignment, and better academic support — emphasizing responsiveness to student needs. On the other hand, the constitutional study advocates for academic freedom as a broader democratic ideal and institutional safeguard, which is essential but less focused on immediate student experience. Our research addresses contemporary issues in Bangladesh's higher education system as experienced in 2025, making it very timely for policy discussions on improving

academic quality and student welfare. While Chowdhury and Sejan's work is critical for long-term legal reform, it might be perceived as more abstract or distant from students' everyday realities.

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Methodology

-MD ISTEAK JAMI

In Bangladesh, where going to university is both a promise and a burden for the students as the lives of Bangladeshi undergraduate students show a careful balance between hope and worry but higher education in Bangladesh is becoming more and more complicated. More Private Universities are being opened along with Public Universities Which makes academic life more complicated. More freedom in governance can mean higher standards for students but the universities that claim to be autonomous more often impose strict rules that impact the future of students. To understand how this autonomy shapes academic pressure and how students respond to it, a careful methodological approach was not only necessary but it was urgent.

A. Research Type

This research follows a mixed analyzed approach, focusing on both qualitative and quantitative perspectives. Quantitatively, the study analyzes statistical data collected through a structured survey via Google Forms asking questions of insights, themes and more as example asking through scenarios and choices of possibilities that helps to understand the judgements. Qualitatively, it interprets responses from students as Statistics expert commentary and institutional insights from the current undergrad students to examine the latest situation on number and more clearly. such as government education policies. This

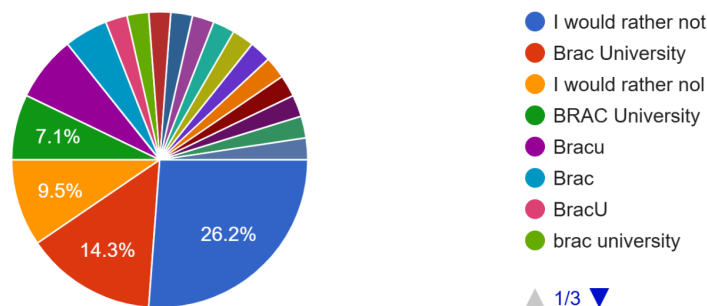
dual-method strategy allows the study to find patterns and perceptions numerically while capturing the emotional and angles of academic stress.

Type of Data

The primary data was collected from an online survey via google form targeted at undergraduate students from various universities of various autonomy across Bangladesh. A number of students responded, offering a different sample of voices from both public and private institutions. The survey contained multiple-choice, alongside open-ended questions that invited students to reflect on their personal stress, their views on university autonomy, and what changes they desired. Also, using clear, humorous options had encouraged honest, relatable responses. It directed autonomy's impact on pressure through control, flexibility, and efficiency. To understand the majority the responses were taken in as charts to show majority and percentage to analyze e.g. charts with percentage.

Can you Write down your University name

42 responses



Demographic Analysis

The demographic distribution of respondents revealed important insights into the profile of students affected by academic stress and institutional policies. Among the participants:

- **72.5%** were from private universities, **21.6%** from public institutions, and **5.9%** from national universities.
- **54.9%** were in their 3rd year of study, **21.6%** in 2nd year, **19.6%** in 4th year, with a minority in the 1st year.
- Gender distribution showed **66.7% male** and **33.3% female** students.
- Most responses came from BRAC University , followed by Dhaka University and Jagannath University among others.

This mix of persons from several backgrounds attending private universities is most likely a consequence of the fact that private higher education in Bangladesh usually reflects more independence and standardizing. Particularly in relation to closely regulated curricula, strict schedules, and aggressive grading, this relates to how students believe that more freedom for institutions results in more academic pressure.

Qualitative responses confirmed this; many students claimed that the main causes of their stress were competitive job markets, rigorous academic calendars, and short semesters.

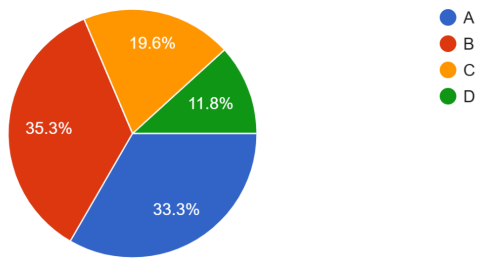
Especially, 85.7% of the respondents claimed that their mental and physical condition suffered from the pressure of their studies. Students at public universities were more likely to say they had more freedom and less academic pressure. This suggests that autonomy does not always lower stress—in some cases, it may even make it worse by putting in place stricter accountability and grading systems. That contradicts the outcome of how freedom should impact on students. It was understood that on paper the process may seem progressive but the reality suggested antithesis of what they were promised.

Limitations



If you had to picture your University decision making autonomy which one of these pictures would describe the best ?

51 responses





Several limitations were encountered during the study. First, there was a lower number of student participants from government-controlled autonomous universities, which may have skewed the dataset toward private sector experiences mostly. The small sample size) also limited broader generalizability. Students from autonomous institutions often expressed a lack of faith in administrative systems, especially when evaluating course design and grading. More humorous and negative responses might indicate the confusion of not understanding the premise but also potentially due to despise or lack of confidence in institutional responsiveness. Which might have made students choose the negative responses mostly despite giving neutral choices.

Moreover, the female participants were much more likely than male. Despite efforts to promote gender equity, women's participation in higher education in Bangladesh remains disproportionately low, with female students comprising only about 43% of the university population as of 2021 (The Daily Star, 2023). It was shown significantly less participants

from women as the survey seemed incomplete as the chart proves the scenario as well. Furthermore, students continuously urged the need for more flexible time management indicating academic calendar. Most felt stressed by consecutive exams, heavy assignments, and limited mental health support. Some also lashed out the frustration with constantly changing policies and the absence of student voices in academic decision-making. These limitations suggest the need for immediate studies and further actions to overcome.

Expert Opinions and Policy Insights

Experts and policy analysts have highly commented on the links in between the academic stress, student well-being, and institutional autonomy in Bangladesh. According to The Daily Star editorial Hasan(2023) that students are pressured almost all the time due to their academic commitments and few institutions offer adequate mental health support.

Apart from private, autonomous university policies that demands exceptional performances without offering any supportive environments but for the young students, this is really tough and inhuman at first.

The Ministry of Education (2010) states that for the National Education Policy of Bangladesh's universities autonomy is a must to operate in a creative and independent manner. Confirming this guarantee was an educational specialist called Manzur Hossain. Furthermore, he claimed that the ministry should behave more as a helper than a policeman (Islam, 2022). To demonstrate how their opinions on autonomy are shifting, more and more academics are condemning schools and advising them to substitute learning environments supporting kids from "hyper-competitive cultures" (Karim, 2023). But the claims are only not taken as a serious issue.

These insights are crucial for interpreting our survey data. For example, **59.6% of respondents** believed that institutional autonomy improves outcomes, yet **81% also agreed or strongly agreed** that it increases academic pressure. This contradiction underlines that autonomy must be paired with student-centric reforms: fair assessment systems, accessible counseling services, and student participation in governance (Hasan, 2023; Karim, 2023).

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Findings

-Jahanara Akter Meem

The survey conducted among 51 undergraduate students aimed to understand how institutional autonomy in Bangladesh’s higher education system impacts academic demands, stress levels, and overall student well-being. The responses reveal a multidimensional portrait of academic pressure, offering insight into the practical consequences of institutional autonomy across private, public, and national universities.

Table 1: Survey Demographics and Key Findings

Category	Response Options	Percentage (%)
University Type	Private	72.5%
	Public	21.6%
	National	5.9%
Year of Study	3rd Year	54.9%
	2nd Year	21.6%
	4th Year	19.6%
	1st Year	2%
	4th Year(miscategorized)	2%
Autonomy Affects Deadlines	Yes	61.9%
	No	38.1%

Health Impact	Affected Mental/Physical Health	85.7%
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No Effect	14.3%
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High stake exam Vs Academic	Help to improve memory	21.4%
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Performance	Increase Anxiety	61.9%
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Encourage Focused and deeper	14.3%
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Learning

Do not Have Effect	2.4%
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Advantage of Spreading Exam	Reduce Last Minute Stress	19%
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Throughout the Year	Improve Steady Learning	40.5%
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Increase Workload	33.3%
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No Impact	7.1%
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Impact of Autonomy on	Increases Options	33.3%
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Course Choice

Unsure	23.8%
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Limits Options	23.8%
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No Impact	19%
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Autonomy = Higher Pressure?	Agree	50%
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	Strongly Agree	31%
	Neutral	14.3%
Have most control over	Government	15.7%
Universities	University Administration	43.1%
	Faculty	15.7%
	Students	13.7%

1. Distribution of Respondents Based on University Type and Year of Study:

The survey participants were primarily enrolled in private universities, accounting for 72.5% of the sample. Public university students made up 21.6%, while those from national universities constituted only 5.9% of respondents. In terms of academic year, the majority of the students were in their third year (54.9%). This was followed by second-year students (21.6%), fourth-year students (19.6%), and first-year students (2%).

2. Perceived Impact of Institutional Autonomy on Academic Deadlines:

Out of the total respondents, 61.9% reported that institutional autonomy affects academic deadlines. The remaining 38.1% did not perceive any effect of autonomy on deadlines.

3. Health Impacts of Academic Pressure:

A significant majority of respondents, 85.7%, indicated that academic pressure had affected their mental and/or physical health. Only 14.3% of the participants stated that they did not experience any health-related impact from academic demands.

4. Perceived Impact of High-Stakes Examinations on Academic Performance:

When asked about the effect of high-stakes exams, 61.9% of respondents noted that such assessments increased their anxiety levels. Another 21.4% reported that high-stakes exams helped improve their memory. A smaller portion (14.3%) believed these exams encouraged focused and deeper learning. Only 2.4% of the participants reported that high-stakes exams did not have any effect on their academic performance.

5. Perceived Advantages of Distributing Examinations Throughout the Academic Year:

In response to the idea of spreading exams across the academic year, 40.5% of respondents believed this would improve steady learning. Meanwhile, 33.3% reported that it would increase their workload. Additionally, 19% indicated that distributing exams would help reduce last-minute stress. Only 7.1% believed there would be no impact from spreading out exams.

6. Impact of Institutional Autonomy on Course Selection Options:

Regarding the influence of institutional autonomy on students' ability to choose courses, 33.3% believed that autonomy increases their options. Another 23.8% were unsure about the impact, while an equal proportion (23.8%) felt that autonomy limits course selection. A minority of 19% reported no impact on their course selection.

7. Perception of Autonomy and Associated Academic Pressure:

Half of the respondents (50%) agreed that autonomy in academic institutions results in higher pressure on students. An additional 31% strongly agreed with this statement. In contrast, 14.3% of participants remained neutral and did not express a clear opinion on the relationship between autonomy and pressure.

8. Perceptions Regarding the Primary Source of Control Over Universities:

When asked about which group has the most control over university operations , 43.1% of respondents identified university administrations as holding the greatest control. Government bodies and faculty members were each identified by 15.7% of students. Students themselves were perceived to have the most control by only 13.7% of respondents.

Summary of the Most Significant Statistical Trends

The data reveals a set of dominant patterns:

1. A large majority of students experience academic pressure with health consequences (85.7%).
2. A significant number of students associate high-stakes exams with increased anxiety (61.9%).
3. Institutional autonomy is widely perceived as increasing student pressure (81% when combining “agree” and “strongly agree” responses).
4. Private university students dominate the sample (72.5%), potentially influencing perceptions of autonomy and administrative control.

General Patterns Related to Academic Experience and Institutional Autonomy

Overall, the findings suggest that students believe institutional autonomy has both positive and negative impacts. While autonomy is seen by some as increasing course selection options (33.3%), it is also associated with heightened pressure (81%) and ambiguous effects on academic deadlines and course management. Students appear divided on whether autonomy enhances or restricts their academic experience, indicating diverse perspectives likely influenced by the type of institution they attend.

Consistency in Responses Across Survey Dimensions

In terms of consistency, students tend to align in their responses on stress and anxiety associated with exams and deadlines. Similarly, opinions about who holds control over universities converge significantly around administrative leadership (43.1%), with less consensus around student or faculty influence.

Outliers and Anomalies in the Dataset

There is a minor anomaly in the self-reported academic year category, where one respondent listed their year as "4rth," suggesting either a typographical or input error. Despite this, the overall data set remains coherent and interpretable.

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Discussion

The results of the survey conducted among 51 undergraduate students in Bangladesh's higher education system provide a compelling narrative about the complex interplay between institutional autonomy and academic pressure. While institutional autonomy is generally assumed to provide greater flexibility and academic freedom, the findings challenge this assumption by revealing that, in the context of Bangladesh, autonomy may also intensify student stress, limit perceived agency, and impose administrative burdens that impact well-being

Autonomy, Academic Pressure, and Well-Being

One of the most striking findings of the survey is that 85.7% of students reported that academic pressure affected their mental and/or physical health, underscoring the significant toll that academic demands take on students. Moreover, 81% of respondents (50% agree and 31% strongly agree) believed that institutional autonomy increases academic pressure. This clearly contradicts Hypothesis 1, which proposed that autonomy reduces academic pressure due to increased flexibility and choice. Instead, the evidence suggests that institutional autonomy, at least in the way it is currently practiced in Bangladesh, may be amplifying pressure rather than alleviating it.

Several factors likely contribute to this paradox. While autonomy can theoretically allow for more adaptive and student-centered approaches, in practice, it appears that universities may be using their autonomy to impose rigorous academic calendars, tight deadlines, and frequent assessments without necessarily improving support structures or responsiveness to student

needs. 61.9% of respondents noted that autonomy affects academic deadlines, possibly reflecting arbitrary or accelerated scheduling by individual institutions.

Impact of Exams and Academic Calendars

The survey strongly supports Hypothesis 2, which emphasized the role of congested exam schedules and academic calendars in elevating stress levels and undermining performance. A substantial 61.9% of respondents stated that high-stakes exams increase anxiety, aligning with findings from Chapell et al. (2005) who reported a strong correlation between test anxiety and reduced academic performance. In contrast, only 21.4% felt such exams helped improve memory, and just 14.3% believed they encouraged deeper learning.

Furthermore, the response to distributed assessments throughout the year reveals ambivalence. While 40.5% said this would improve steady learning, 33.3% feared it would increase workload. These perceptions suggest that while students are aware of potential academic benefits from restructured assessments, the prevailing workload already feels overwhelming. Thus, any restructuring must be approached carefully, with clear institutional support.

Curriculum Control and Course Choice

Institutional autonomy is theoretically supposed to empower universities to develop innovative, relevant curricula. However, findings related to course choice reflect mixed outcomes. Only 33.3% of respondents believed that autonomy increased their course selection options, while 23.8% felt it limited their options, and another 23.8% were unsure. This directly challenges Hypothesis 1 and Hypothesis 3, which anticipated that autonomy would expand course choices and increase curricular flexibility. Instead, it seems that despite autonomy, many institutions may not be fully capitalizing on their freedom to update

curricula or diversify offerings. As Hypothesis 4 suggests, the presence of outdated courses and rigid structures persists, likely due to slow bureaucratic adjustments and a lack of responsive curriculum development mechanisms.

This stagnation may also reflect a deeper misalignment between autonomy and broader systemic support. Autonomy without robust accountability, faculty development, and policy coherence can lead to inconsistency in academic standards and ineffective governance. In such a context, universities may struggle to balance innovation with administrative coherence, resulting in stress for both students and staff.

Governance and Perceived Institutional Control

Another critical area explored was the perception of control within universities. 43.1% of students believe that university administrations have the most control, compared to just 13.7% who believe students do. This power asymmetry reflects a potential disconnect between autonomy at the institutional level and agency at the student level. Autonomy that is primarily administrative or bureaucratic, rather than pedagogical or student-focused, may lead to more rigid structures under the guise of independence.

Such a concentration of power can exacerbate the issues mentioned in Hypothesis 3—namely, that limited autonomy at the student and faculty level constrains curriculum responsiveness and scheduling flexibility. Faculty and students may lack real influence in decisions related to assessments, workload, and support systems, further contributing to a sense of helplessness and pressure.

Institutional Differences and Sample Composition

It is also important to contextualize these findings within the demographics of the sample. 72.5% of respondents were from private universities, which typically operate with more autonomy compared to public and national institutions. This overrepresentation may have skewed perceptions of autonomy, as private institutions in Bangladesh often adopt stricter academic schedules and administrative controls to maintain competitive standards. In contrast, public universities—often constrained by government policies—might offer more lenient academic timelines but less responsiveness in curriculum development.

Hence, the findings may be more reflective of the pressures associated with privatized autonomy rather than systemic autonomy across all institution types. Nonetheless, the consistency of stress-related responses across all respondents suggests a broader trend that transcends specific institutional classifications.

Implications and Conclusion

The survey results offer a nuanced view of the impact of institutional autonomy in Bangladesh's higher education landscape. While autonomy is intended to promote innovation and flexibility, its current implementation appears to intensify academic pressure rather than alleviate it. Student perceptions reveal a system where autonomy is largely administrative, not pedagogical, and where increased independence does not translate to improved student experience. The data challenge Hypothesis 1 and 3, which expected autonomy to reduce pressure and enhance academic agency. They partially support Hypothesis 2, especially in terms of the stress induced by exam regimes and congested academic schedules. They also validate elements of Hypothesis 4, as outdated curricula and rigid structures persist despite the presence of autonomy.

Moving forward, institutional autonomy must be reframed not merely as independence from government control, but as a mechanism to empower academic communities—especially students and faculty—to engage meaningfully in curriculum design, assessment methods, and institutional governance. Without such a reorientation, autonomy risks becoming a hollow reform, one that shifts pressure rather than solving it.

In conclusion, while autonomy holds potential, its effectiveness in reducing academic pressure depends significantly on how it is implemented. For autonomy to contribute positively to student well-being and educational outcomes, it must be coupled with inclusive governance, flexible curriculum design, mental health support, and a genuine commitment to pedagogical innovation.

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Findings

—MD TAHMIN BATEN

The survey conducted among 51 undergraduate students aimed to understand how institutional autonomy in Bangladesh’s higher education system impacts academic demands, stress levels, and overall student well-being. The responses reveal a multidimensional portrait of academic pressure, offering insight into the practical consequences of institutional autonomy across private, public, and national universities.

Table 1: Survey Demographics and Key Findings

Category	Response Options	Percentage (%)
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University Type	Private	72.5%	
	Public	21.6%	
	National	5.9%	
Year of Study	3rd Year	54.9%	
	2nd Year	21.6%	
	4th Year	19.6%	
	1st Year	2%	
	4th Year(miscategorized)	2%	2%
Autonomy Affects Deadlines	Yes	61.9%	
	No	38.1%	
Health Impact	Affected Mental/Physical Health	85.7%	
	No Effect	14.3%	
High stake exam Vs Academic Performance	Help to improve memory	21.4%	
	Increase Anxiety	61.9%	
	Encourage Focused and deeper Learning	14.3%	
	Do not Have Effect	2.4%	
Advantage of Spreading Exam	Reduce Last Minute Stress	19%	
Throughout the Year	Improve Steady Learning	40.5%	
	Increase Workload	33.3%	
	No Impact	7.1%	
Impact of Autonomy on Course Choice	Increases Options	33.3%	
	Unsure	23.8%	
	Limits Options	23.8%	

	No Impact	19%
Autonomy = Higher Pressure?	Agree	50%
	Strongly Agree	31%
	Neutral	14.3%
Have most control over	Government	15.7%
Universities	University Administration	43.1%
	Faculty	15.7%
	Students	13.7%

1. Distribution of Respondents Based on University Type and Year of Study:

The survey participants were primarily enrolled in private universities, accounting for 72.5% of the sample. Public university students made up 21.6%, while those from national universities constituted only 5.9% of respondents. In terms of academic year, the majority of the students were in their third year (54.9%). This was followed by second-year students (21.6%), fourth-year students (19.6%), and first-year students (2%).

2. Perceived Impact of Institutional Autonomy on Academic Deadlines:

Out of the total respondents, 61.9% reported that institutional autonomy affects academic deadlines. The remaining 38.1% did not perceive any effect of autonomy on deadlines.

3. Health Impacts of Academic Pressure:

A significant majority of respondents, 85.7%, indicated that academic pressure had affected their mental and/or physical health. Only 14.3% of the participants stated that they did not experience any health-related impact from academic demands.

4. Perceived Impact of High-Stakes Examinations on Academic Performance:

When asked about the effect of high-stakes exams, 61.9% of respondents noted that such assessments increased their anxiety levels. Another 21.4% reported that high-stakes exams helped improve their memory. A smaller portion (14.3%) believed these exams encouraged focused and deeper learning. Only 2.4% of the participants reported that high-stakes exams did not have any effect on their academic performance.

5. Perceived Advantages of Distributing Examinations Throughout the Academic Year:

In response to the idea of spreading exams across the academic year, 40.5% of respondents believed this would improve steady learning. Meanwhile, 33.3% reported that it would increase their workload. Additionally, 19% indicated that distributing exams would help reduce last-minute stress. Only 7.1% believed there would be no impact from spreading out exams.

6. Impact of Institutional Autonomy on Course Selection Options:

Regarding the influence of institutional autonomy on students' ability to choose courses, 33.3% believed that autonomy increases their options. Another 23.8% were unsure about the impact, while an equal proportion (23.8%) felt that autonomy limits course selection. A minority of 19% reported no impact on their course selection.

7. Perception of Autonomy and Associated Academic Pressure:

Half of the respondents (50%) agreed that autonomy in academic institutions results in higher pressure on students. An additional 31% strongly agreed with this statement. In contrast, 14.3% of participants remained neutral and did not express a clear opinion on the relationship between autonomy and pressure.

8. Perceptions Regarding the Primary Source of Control Over Universities:

When asked about which group has the most control over university operations, 43.1% of respondents identified university administrations as holding the greatest control. Government

bodies and faculty members were each identified by 15.7% of students. Students themselves were perceived to have the most control by only 13.7% of respondents.

Summary of the Most Significant Statistical Trends

The data reveals a set of dominant patterns:

1. A large majority of students experience academic pressure with health consequences (85.7%).
2. A significant number of students associate high-stakes exams with increased anxiety (61.9%).
3. Institutional autonomy is widely perceived as increasing student pressure (81% when combining “agree” and “strongly agree” responses).
4. Private university students dominate the sample (72.5%), potentially influencing perceptions of autonomy and administrative control.

General Patterns Related to Academic Experience and Institutional Autonomy

Overall, the findings suggest that students believe institutional autonomy has both positive and negative impacts. While autonomy is seen by some as increasing course selection options (33.3%), it is also associated with heightened pressure (81%) and ambiguous effects on academic deadlines and course management. Students appear divided on whether autonomy enhances or restricts their academic experience, indicating diverse perspectives likely influenced by the type of institution they attend.

Consistency in Responses Across Survey Dimensions

In terms of consistency, students tend to align in their responses on stress and anxiety associated with exams and deadlines. Similarly, opinions about who holds control over universities converge significantly around administrative leadership (43.1%), with less consensus around student or faculty influence.

Outliers and Anomalies in the Dataset

There is a minor anomaly in the self-reported academic year category, where one respondent listed their year as "4rth," suggesting either a typographical or input error. Despite this, the overall data set remains coherent and interpretable.

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